RFID-Based Automated Student Attendance System

D.R.Palliyaguru - 230459U
Department of Electrical Engineering
University of Moratuwa
Katubedda, Sri Lanka
palliyagurudr.23@uom.lk

B.G.A.Y.Pamod - 230460N
Department of Electrical Engineering
University of Moratuwa
Katubedda, Sri Lanka
pamodbgay.23@uom.lk

S.Panuharan - 230462X
Department of Electrical Engineering
University of Moratuwa
Katubedda, Sri Lanka
panuharans.23@uom.lk

***Abstract*—Manually marking attendance in laboratory classes can be very tedious and time-consuming. In fact, it may even lead to errors and cannot handle large groups of students effectively. This can lead to long queues, accuracy issues, and even proxy marking. To counter all these issues, this paper highlights an RFID-Based Automated Student Attendance System designed specifically for laboratory setups.**

The system will make use of an RFID card for each student, which will be read by an RFID scanner fixed at the entrance or desk in the laboratory. The system is expected to reduce queuing, increase the accuracy of student data, and reduce the employees' workload. Other factors to be considered include fraudulent activities, dealing with the possibility of a student losing their card, network failure, and student confidentiality. The system will act as a cost-effective mechanism for an educational institution to obtain an efficient attendance system.

***Index Terms*—RFID, Automated attendance system, Student identification, Laboratory automation, Access control**

I. Introduction

Attendance tracking is a significant administrative function for higher education institutions, especially for lab-based subjects, which usually require attendance and compliance. In spite of the availability of technology, universities use a lot of manual systems such as paper-based forms and verbal rolling calls even today. Such systems are inefficient and prone to human errors, and it becomes troublesome to handle a large number of students.

Manual attendance platforms tend to result in a rush at the start of laboratory sessions, thus shortening the time period used in conducting experiments. In addition to this, discrepancies arising from illegible handwriting, misplaced files, or late entries can affect the validity of the laboratory attendance sheets. These platforms can fall prone to misuse, including the scenario of students attending on behalf of others. Radio Frequency Identification (RFID) technology is also an attractive alternative as it allows quick processing and identification without contact. Moreover, the attendance management system based on RFID technology is capable of automatically marking attendance in seconds, thus increasing accuracy. Further, attendance data can be safely stored and updated through central database management by associating RFID readers.

This paper discusses the RFID-Based Automated Student Attendance System that has been developed for the laboratory setting. It aims for the elimination of queues, the enhancement of readability, the removal of fraudulent actions, and ensuring scalability in a cost-effective and privacy-protected manner.

Fig. 1. Visualization of a student check-in using an RFID tag bangle in an automated attendance system.

II. Literature Review

Attendance management at educational institutions using RFID has been extensively researched owing to its speed, automation support, as well as low operation cost. In the initial stages, the usage of RFID was confined to the replacement of traditional pen-and-paper attendance management by simple card scan-based RFID systems. There has been substantial improvement in terms of time efficiency as well as accuracy.

However, certain studies demonstrate challenges that may arise with RFID-based attendance systems. Variations in tag positioning may influence the accuracy of tag reads and cause repeat or missed reads of students' IDs when processing their attendance. Studies indicate that a combination of multiple antennas and filtering by signal strength may enhance detection rates.

Lost or forgotten RFID cards have remained an operational challenge. Methods used for this include temporary override, authentication using QR code, or through verification at the help desk, which focuses on recording these exceptions for auditing to avoid abuse. Also, cost, scalability, and maintainability have remained important in large-scale implementations.

It is observed that, although RFID-based attendance management systems give a robust platform for automation, there is a requirement for more efficient design in the context of congestion, security, exception handling, and robustness from existing literature.

III. Problem Statement

Currently, most of the laboratory attendance registration systems in use are manual, which is very inefficient, especially when dealing with large institutions. Manual attendance sometimes causes students to form queues at the lab entrances, which might affect the time spent in class. Manual registration also results in tutors and lab assistants spending too much time dealing with attendance registration as opposed to teaching. Moreover, manual registration is prone to forgery and losses.

There exist some existing solutions that try to overcome these limitations by using RFID. Although these solutions can improve the automated system and minimize human involvement, there arise some constraints. The single reader system may cause congestion during the peak entry process, leading to delays as in the manual system. Also, the deployment of inexpensive RFID tags can cause security problems, as these tags can easily be cloned and abused. The treatment of exceptional circumstances, for example, losing and leaving an tag behind, still has to involve human participation, thus hampering system efficiency.

However, to overcome such limitations, there is an apparent need to develop an RFID system that is faster, more accurate, secure, scalable, and robust while being cost-effective and suitable for laboratory use. The system needs to accommodate a smooth and continuous entry process for students during peak times and provide systems that can restrict unauthorized use of tags as well as entry duplication. Having offline capabilities that assist in uninterrupted system functioning during temporary loss of connectivity is also necessary, along with effective synchronization of data when connectivity is reinstated. Furthermore, integration of systems with institutional database mechanisms is key for efficient record management and effective reporting of data. By this means, it is hoped that a feasible solution can be offered that is suitable for contemporary educational institutions.

IV. System Overview

The RFID-Based Automated Student Attendance System is intended to automate students' marking of attendance inside laboratory settings with a high level of accuracy and speed and reliability of results. Such a system is made up of RFID chips/labels/tags, fixed RFID readers, an embedded processing unit, and a central server or cloud database.

Every student is given an identifier card that is equipped with an RFID tag. These RFID readers are located either at the lab entrances or at the identified scanning points. As soon as the students approach within the operation range of the reader, the identifier code is scanned together with the time stamp and the reader's location.

This collected data is then processed by the local microcontroller or system, which checks for the validity of the data through duplicate scans and temporarily stores the data in cases where the network is interrupted. The valid attendance data is then sent for verification to the central server for the tag ID to match the database records and the Learning Management System.

The system is modular and scalable and can be implemented at multiple labs. It is able to work without interruption with the help of local buffering in case of failure in the network; on the other hand, security policies prevent repeated scanning and proxy attendance.

Operational Workflow

The operational workflow of the RFID-based attendance system, as illustrated in Fig. 2, is summarized through the following key stages:

1) *Student Arrival and RFID Scanning:* The process begins when a student arrives at the laboratory and presents the RFID-enabled identification card within the operating range of the RFID reader. The reader wirelessly detects the tag and initiates communication without requiring physical contact or precise alignment.
2) *Tag Reading and Validation:* The RFID reader extracts the unique tag ID and forwards it to the embedded controller for validation. The system verifies the correctness of the tag ID and checks for duplicate scans within a predefined time window to prevent multiple or fraudulent entries.
3) *Local Storage and Buffering:* Once validated, the attendance record—consisting of the tag ID, timestamp, and reader location—is temporarily stored in local memory. This buffering mechanism ensures uninterrupted operation and prevents data loss during temporary network failures.
4) *Server Transmission and Verification:* The locally stored data is transmitted to the central server or cloud-based backend when network connectivity is available. The server verifies the student's identity and enrollment status using the institutional database.
5) *Attendance Update and Logging:* Verified attendance records are permanently stored in the database and synchronized with the Learning Management System. Invalid or duplicate scans are rejected and logged separately for monitoring, auditing, and system diagnostics.

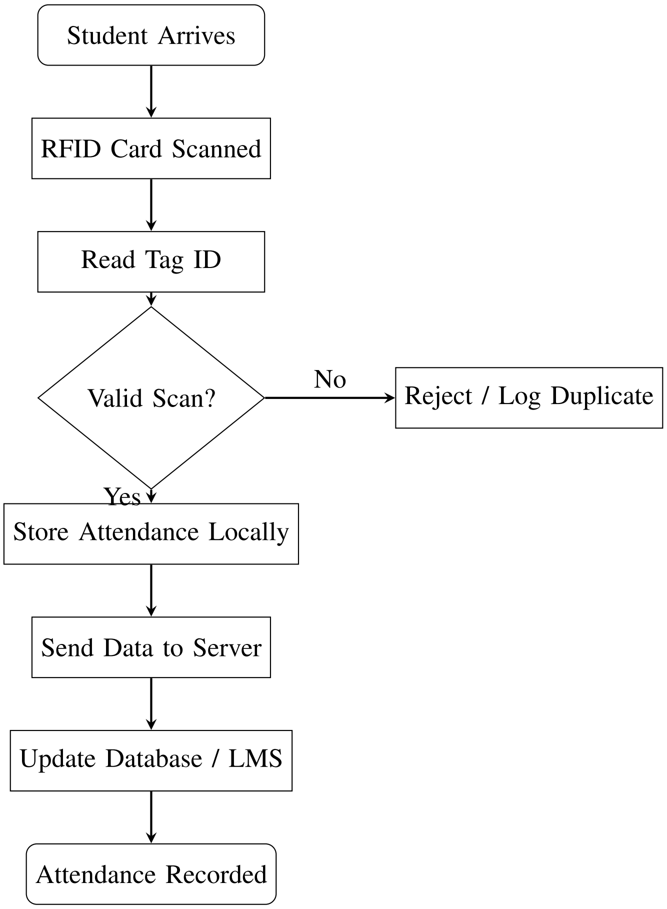

Fig. 2. Operational Flowchart of the RFID-Based Attendance System

V. System Design

A. Central Controller

The main controller acts as the main processing unit of the RFID-based attendance system. Its role includes the management of the communication process among the RFID readers, the backend server, as well as the handling of data on a real-time process. On the reception of the data from the reader, it undertakes preliminary validation, including format checks, elimination of duplicates, and the generation of time stamps on the attendance.

It also controls timing within the system and handles response during peak times of entering data in the lab. With the controller handling validation, unnecessary traffic in the network is avoided. In case of unavailability of the network, functionality is not hampered as data is allowed to be buffered locally until the connection is regained.

B. RFID Tags and Readers

The RFID identification subsystem is the main system used for recognition of the students. Every student is given an institutional identification card embedded with an RFID tag having a unique identifier. Passive RFID tags are employed because they are cheaper, robust, smaller in size, and require no maintenance, as they are self-sustaining and do not need any power source.

Fixed RFID readers are mounted either at the entry points or scanning locations in the laboratory. In essence, these fixed RFID readers constantly produce radio-frequency signals that detect RFID tags entering the scanning zone. When the student produces the identification card, the reader initiates contactless communication with the card, which consequently reads the identity of the RFID tag in less than a second.

Fig. 3. Prototype of a RFID Tag Bangle made with SOLIDWORKS

C. Data Management and Networking

The attendance information gathered from the RFID readers is integrated with system-created metadata, such as timestamping and reader position, for processing. Verified attendance information is held in temporary memory for reliability in case there is a short-term disruption in the network. The temporary memory buffer prevents loss of data and allows for continuous system function.

Once connectivity is established, the stored attendance information is sent via secure communication channels to a centralized server or cloud database. The main function of the access control system is to only allow accredited computer systems and individuals to view or alter the attendance information. Procedures are in place to encrypt and verify theendance information of the learners while maintaining compliance with overall privacy policies. The centralized database allows real-time viewing and automatic integration between the institution's Learning Management System.

VI. Simulations and Results

This section presents the simulation setup and performance evaluation of the proposed RFID-based attendance system. The system was modeled and analyzed under realistic operating conditions to validate its functionality and efficiency. Key performance metrics such as throughput, read reliability, and response time were considered to assess the effectiveness of the system during typical and peak usage scenarios.

A. General RFID System

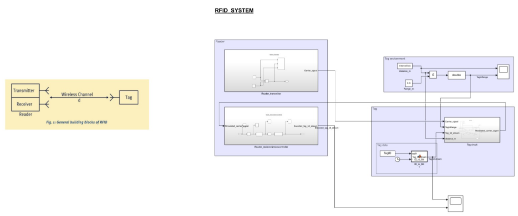

Fig. 4.

Fig.4. shows the general architecture of the RFID-based attendance system. The system consists of an RFID reader, a wireless communication channel, and an RFID tag. The reader comprises a transmitter and a receiver. The transmitter generates a radio frequency (RF) carrier signal that propagates through the wireless channel toward the tag. The RFID tag modulates the received carrier signal with its stored identification data using backscatter modulation and reflects it back to the reader. The receiver processes the backscattered signal to extract the tag identification data, which is used for attendance recording.

Verification of RFID Tag Detection

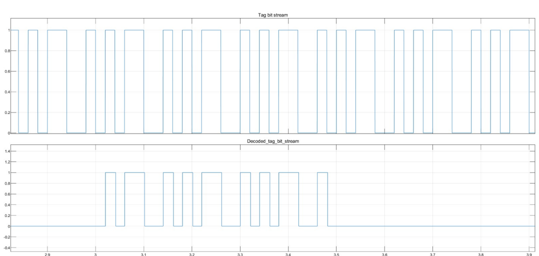

Fig. 5.

The tag bit stream symbolizes the original digital information associated with the RFID tag ID (101) modulated using backscatter modulation. The decoded tag bit stream is obtained after demodulation, filtering, and decoding of the received signal at the RFID reader. The point-to-point mapping relationship existing between the original bit stream and the decoded bit stream, as evident from Fig.5., validates the correct tag identification with no errors and the correctness of the RFID identification subsystem.

B. Abstract RFID Attendance System (Input–Blackbox–Output Model)

The RFID system created is an abstraction of an input-blackbox-output system that models the logical process of an attendance system using RFID technology without focusing on RF transmission and hardware signal processing. The system is based on data flow validation and attendance recording.

System Overview

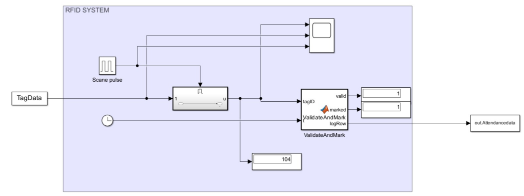

Fig. 6. simulation of the black box model

The model receives Tag ID as its inputs and then evaluates the data using a black box that simulates the working of the RFID reader and the attendance system. The working of the tags, such as identification, validation, and marking, is concealed inside the black box. This makes the model oblivious to the details of the working.

Input The input to the abstract RFID attendance system is based on RFID identification information provided for RFID tags at distinct times when their scanning is performed. The input event is in the form of a distinct identification for every RFID tag and the time at which its scanning is performed. The input described is abstract because it is based on RFID identification and times.

```
>> TagData.time = [1 5 9 13 17];
TagData.signals.values = [101; 102; 103; 101; 104];
TagData.signals.dimensions = 1;
```

Fig. 7. Input of the black box model

Output The system produces output in the form of a processed attendance record that is generated after scanning and validating the scanned RFID tags. The generated output for each scanned and validated tag ID contains tag ID, detection time, and confirmation of attendance. Invalid or repeated scans of tags are treated in line with system rules. The final output is in the form of an organized record of attendance marking authorized users' presence.

```
>> RFID_abstractcode
FINAL ATTENDANCE LIST
    Time      TagID     Valid     Marked
    ____      _____     _____     ______

      4        101        1          1
      8        102        1          1
     12        103        1          1
     20        104        1          1
```

Fig. 8. Output of the black box model

C. Reader Transmitter Subsystem

The reader transmitter system is shown in Fig.9. The task of this system is to produce the required RF carrier signal

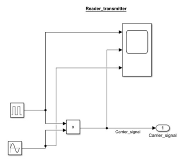

Fig. 9.

for the RFID communication process. The production of the sinusoidal carrier signal is accomplished and regulated by a switching signal that is in pulses. The multiplication of the two signals makes sure that the data is sent only during the active interrogation phase. The produced RF carrier signal is sent to the RFID tag and functions as the reference signal in the backscattering process.

D. RFID Tag Circuit Subsystem

Fig.10. is the circuit subsystem of the RFID tag, which is used in the suggested system. The tag receives the incident RF carrier signal from the reader first and checks if the conditions of signal strength and range are satisfactory. When it gets activated, the tag modulates the carrier signal with its stored binary identification data by changing the reflection coefficient. In order to take into account the real distance-dependent wireless signal propagation, some distance-dependent coupling effects are included. The modulated carrier signal is reflected back towards the reader.

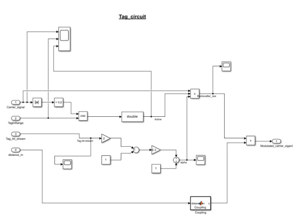

Fig. 10.

E. Reader Receiver and Microcontroller Subsystem

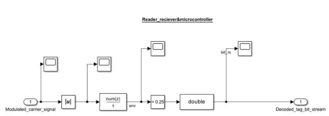

Fig. 11.

Fig.11: Reader receiver and microcontroller subsystem. The envelope detection, comprising an absolute value operation followed by low-pass filtering, is applied to the backscattered signal that has been received from the RFID tag. The resultant envelope is matched with a threshold in order to convert the entire signal into a digital bit stream. This decoded bit stream essentially represents the tag identification data and hence is forwarded to the microcontroller for further processing and storage for attendance.

CONCLUSION

RFID-Based Automated Student Attendance System presents an innovative solution for overcoming the challenges posed by conventional computerized and manual student attendance marking systems used in laboratory settings. By using the RFID system for automating student attendance marking, congestion, errors, and the administrative burden can be prevented.

Designing the system, the emphasis has been on scalability, security, and resilience, incorporating techniques for fraud, lost cards, and network outages. Even if the RFID technology has proved efficacious, there is scope for improvement in the area of security, which can include techniques like hybrid authentication approaches, reader positioning, and the cost of deployment.

Thus, the system presents a feasible and efficient method for contemporary universities that demand accurate and automated student attendance management.

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